these devilish creations will be installed for a nuclear war, for nuclear suicide,' Honecker warned, adding that the FRG would be transformed into a 'nuclear launching pad for Washington', and exposed to a devastating counterstrike. He pleaded:

Really, no one can be uncertain about the far-reaching consequences for the future of détente that will result from the implementation of this decision. That these weapons should not be deployed is the forceful demand of all those who support peace and a secure future for Europe, because the prospect of a nuclear war is not acceptable.

3

Between January and December 1983, the press tallied over thirty Honecker speeches, most dealing with some aspect of the nuclear crisis.

Meanwhile, relations between East Berlin and Bonn took a sudden dive. When a West German citizen, Rudolf Burkert, died suddenly during an interrogation at a border checkpoint, the incident presented problems for Honecker and highlighted the rough treatment meted out to FRG visitors to the East.

'Strangely enough,' noted the daily Westfalen Blatt, 'many citizens who take almost casual note of the dramatic incidents along the intra-German death strip, have become sensitive to the situation because of the Burkert case. Could this be because the victim was an FRG citizens this time?'4 Though there was no indication physical force was applied at the border, the episode inflamed widespread anger in the FRG and prompted Helmut Kohl, the Chancellor who had succeeded Helmut Schmidt, to call for a thorough investigation. 'In truth,' Honecker explained to Kohl during a phone call, Burkert 'had suffered a heart attack', and there was 'no culpable conduct by GDR organs'.5